

THE INCUMBENT Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath at a rally in Ayodhya on February 22

AKHILESH HAS CONVERTED THE CONTEST INTO A DIRECT CHIEF MINISTERIAL BATTLE WITH YOGI ADITYANATH AND TURNED A DISUNITED, DISPIRITED SP INTO A CATALYTIC, COMBAT-READY FIGHTING UNIT

as the prime challenger to the BJP. He has converted what is usually a tri-cornered contest, with four-time CM Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) being the third pole, into a distinctly bipolar contest. He has pulled a disunited, dispirited SP out of the morass it had fallen into after the 2017 debacle and turned it into a catalytic, combat-ready fighting unit capable of challenging the world's biggest party. And he has cleverly converted the battle into a chief ministerial contest between incumbent Yogi Adityanath and himself, studiously avoiding making direct references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. That the BJP is rattled is evident. Both Modi and Yogi can be found targeting mostly Akhilesh in their campaign speeches rather than Mayawati or state Congress chief Priyanka Gandhi. Psephologist Sanjay Kumar, director of CSDS Lok Niti, is one of those who believes the BJP will form a government again in the state, but he acknowledges, "It is a tight election and Akhilesh is like a one-man army against the formidable BJP. He may push up the SP's tally to 140 seats, which is huge, considering the party's dismal tally of 47 in 2017."

Akhilesh, though, is not satisfied with being classified as second best and believes he and his party can win. In the five years out of power, he worked to gain full control